

ing Africa, have created autonomous agencies that are freed from strict public service rules enabling autonomy in the hiring and management of public employees. Others employ performance-based contracts within the public service that reward or punish performance based upon clearly established and measurable criteria. Among successful attempts to fight corruption are the formation of independent anti-corruption commissions (Hong Kong and Singapore) and more recently integrity committees within public agencies (Tanzania and Zambia). The lessons from experience suggest they work when they are genuinely independent and there is strong political will to tackle corruption.

Second, there is an increased responsibility being placed on civil society organisations to hold public officials accountable, which is increasingly being called as social accountability. In India, there are several accountability tools being used by different groups including citizen report cards, social audits and budget analysis. Strengthened by the strong Right to Information (RTI) law and supported by the media, such groups are raising questions about public sector performance and bringing corruption to light in many arenas. The core strategy in such initiatives is to make state failures in meeting obligations public, thus raising reputational and political costs.

Yet, the problem with both these routes to reforming public services is the lack of teeth. On one hand, anti-corruption commissions can expose major corruption, but without the authority to fire corrupt officials, actions lack bite. Performance-based contracts can create incentives for some officials to improve, but without the possibility of dismissing unproductive workers, they are unlikely to induce reluctant officials to perform. Similarly, increasing managerial autonomy to deploy resources has limited impact, if managers cannot let go poor workers and hire more talented staff. On the other, social accountability has a limited effect if it does not trigger sanctions or shame public officers into improving. Groups engaged in social accountability efforts do not have the power to sanction officials—it is assumed that the force of media, public debate, reputational damage and the triggering of more traditional accountability mechanisms like audits will.

What is needed then for both these sets of reforms to work is a mechanism for sanctioning corrupt public officials. The RTI Act in India has made a first step towards this by penalising individual bureaucrats who fail to provide information within 30 days. But we need to make it easier to fire them. The tenure for life enjoyed by the public sector is the reason why bureaucrats continue to behave with little impunity. Secure in their jobs, they have no fear.

However, what was the thinking behind the tenure for life element? There are many countries whose public services are not characterised by such security of tenure. In Mexico, public sector officials are appointed by politicians and change when the political party changes power. Here, public position is not a guarantee of a job for life, rather the fortunes of public servants are tied up with the fate of their political bosses. The origins of tenure for life concept can be traced to the thinking of Max Weber, one of the earliest observers of modern administration. Weber, writing in the late 1800s, celebrated

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bureaucracy as an improvement on previous forms of administration which he viewed as decentralised, arbitrary, unpredictable and relied on private resources of public officials. Bureaucracy meant a centralisation of administrative power and a separation of the private from the public. In doing this, the public official is expected to work towards